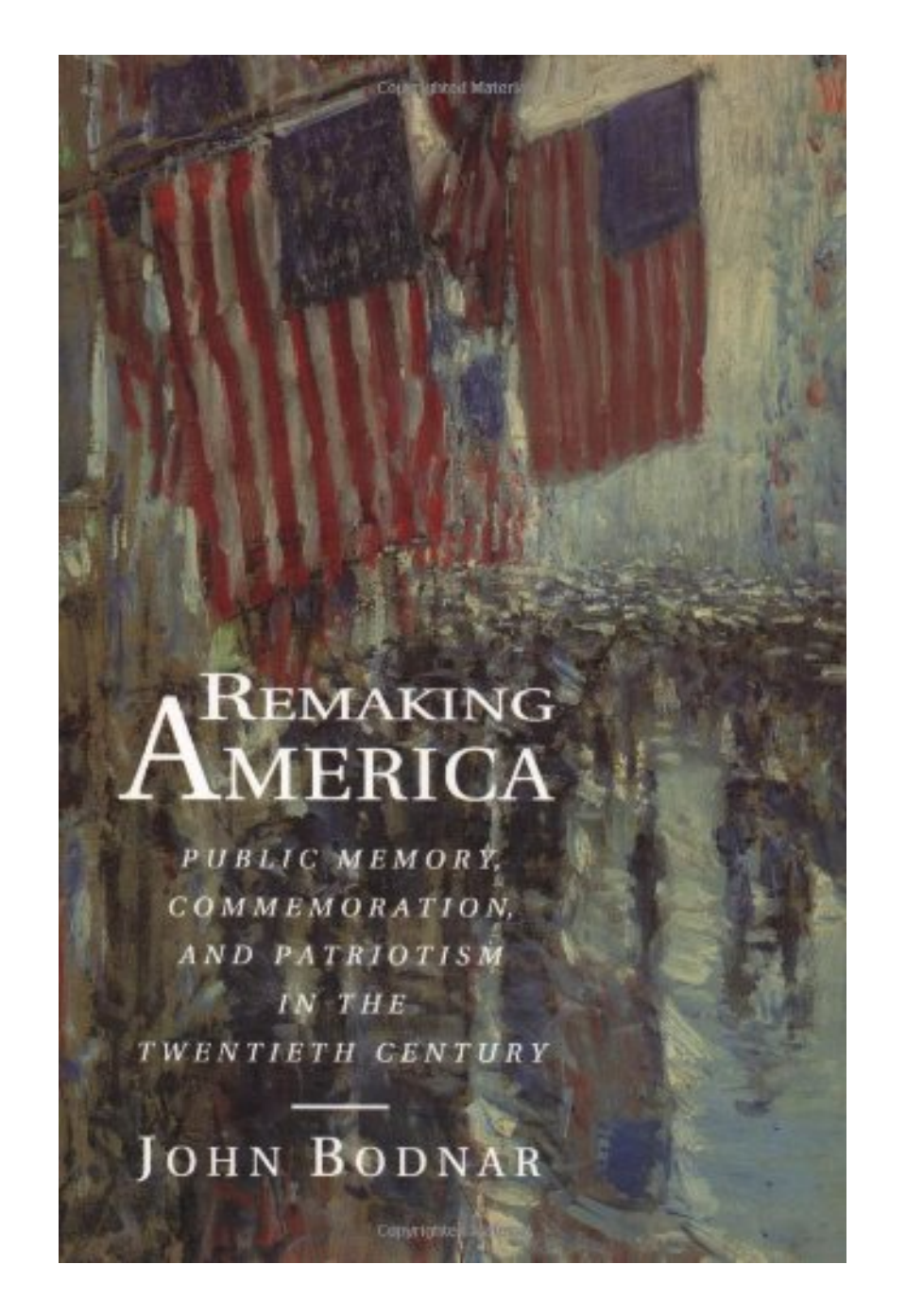




Copyrighted Material

REMAKING AMERICA

*PUBLIC MEMORY,
COMMEMORATION,
AND PATRIOTISM
IN THE
TWENTIETH CENTURY*

JOHN BODNAR

Copyrighted Material

The Vietnam Veterans Memorial

IN 1979, Jan Scruggs, Tom Carhart, and other Vietnam veterans in the Washington, D.C., area began to formulate a plan to build a memorial to the casualties of that conflict. They were not interested in reviving the political arguments over the merits of the war or lauding their fellow soldiers for their patriotism. They wanted, like ordinary people before them, to connect the past and the present in a personal and manageable way. Moved by the attitude of many Vietnam veterans that the nation had betrayed and neglected them after their return home, Scruggs and Carhart sought to give consolation and recognition to their fellow soldiers. Many of the veterans who endorsed their cause were equally intent on removing the "stigma" they felt their actions had evoked in fighting an unpopular war. They wanted to remember the dead and reinterpret the role they had played in the conflict itself.¹

The path that Scruggs, Carhart, and their supporters followed to build their memorial was not only fraught with difficulties but provided a graphic illustration of the various interests that had to be served in any attempt at public commemoration. First, they had to solicit the support of prominent leaders in the government. John Warner, who as Secretary of the Navy during much of the war had signed orders sending thousands of Marines and sailors into combat, promised to help. Senator Gary Hart of Colorado backed the group and cited the need to memorialize the act of sacrificing for the nation. Other senators and leaders talked of the need to promote national solidarity and healing after the discord of the Vietnam era in the United States, something that had not motivated the veterans who conceived of the memorial in the first place. Senator Jake Garn said that the merits of the war could be debated by historians and statesmen, but it was important now to promote a national sense of reconciliation and loyalty to the nation. In fact, Scruggs and other veterans who worked on the memorial's behalf stressed how important it was for them to argue that the monument would promote healing and reconciliation in their discussions with government officials. Ultimately, Scruggs and the Vietnam Veterans Memorial Foundation accommodated the interests of government leaders in unity by selecting

a site for their monument near the Lincoln Memorial. They felt that the ability of Lincoln to represent the oneness of the union would help generate support for their own cause.²

The publicity generated by the proponents of the memorial elicited support not only from influential political leaders but from ordinary citizens throughout the country. In letters sent to the Vietnam Veterans Memorial Fund in Washington these people explained their reasons for contributing to the memorial project. Few mentioned the need for national unity that dominated the thinking of many leaders but some used the symbol of patriotism for reaching a sense of personal understanding about the loss of loved ones. A man in Delaware, whose only son had been killed in the war, wanted "to honor those who have given their best and their all for the security of our country." Others desired to commemorate those who demonstrated "The Love of Our Country."³

Most letter writers, however, claimed to be motivated neither by a desire for unity nor patriotism but by empathy for the soldiers who suffered and died. Many indicated that they saw their contributions as a way to relieve grief. Parents remembered dead sons. One couple sent funds to Bob Hope, who helped the veterans solicit money, and said that the loss of their son was still a "real heartache." Wayne Buchner of Worthington, Ohio, indicated what the reality of the war's aftermath felt like for many when he claimed that Vietnam veterans "living and dead received a 'raw deal' from their country and its people," and deserve "recognition for their valiant efforts." One woman exclaimed that her "heart broke" thinking of "how awful these men were treated." Many added that while they wished to express sorrow and respect for living and dead soldiers, however, their contributions in no way reflected their support for the war itself. A woman from Michigan saw the soldiers as courageous but victims of "needless sacrifice." One man sent funds for the "war I hated and the friends and loved ones I lost."⁴

The final design for the memorial was more of an expression of grief and sorrow than a celebration of national unity or the glorious triumph of the nation. Skewed toward the personal interests of ordinary people, this design glorified neither the nation nor the sacrifices of foot soldiers for magnificent national causes. The veterans had left the design up to a committee that included a number of people with artistic and design expertise. The result was two long, black granite walls that intersected to form the shape of a chevron. Inscribed in the stone were simply the names of each of the fifty-eight thousand men and women who gave their lives in Southeast Asia between 1957 and 1975. No national symbols were used in this design and no particular refer-

ences were made to the ideal of national service. Rather the motif was a testament to ordinary people who had lived and died, not to any idea of national greatness or heroism. The designer, a young art student at Yale University, Maya Ying Lin, thought the memorial conveyed the idea that war was sad. In many ways it resembled the cemeteries that were erected in the South immediately after the Civil War where people could honor those they had lost and express their grief. It would be several decades after the war before the South began to celebrate the nobility of the "Lost Cause" and Civil War military leaders such as Robert E. Lee who were praised for their efforts at promoting national reconciliation.

The selection of an actual design, however, forced monument promoters to consider the symbolic meaning of their plans more than they had done previously. This reassessment revealed fundamental differences among leaders of the monument project and other supporters that revolved around the issue of the power of large political structures such as the nation-state. Scruggs and others were satisfied that the monument commemorated their comrades. Others, however, were angered by what they perceived to be a lack of patriotism and glory. James Webb, who had served as an officer in Vietnam, felt the design looked like a "mass grave" and that it needed a flag and white walls. Wealthy Texas businessman H. Ross Perot, who had funded the design competition, did not like the plan either and felt it only commemorated the "guys that died." Tom Carhart now reconsidered his staunch support for the memorial because it seemed "anti-heroic" and failed to promote the notion of duty to the nation, an ideal he was certainly exposed to in his training at West Point. Carhart called the design a "black gash of shame" and pleaded for patriotism and nationalism when he explained, "We want something that will make us part of America."⁵

Letters to officials of the memorial fund added to the public outcry over the lack of patriotism and the failure to interpret the past deeds of soldiers in other than heroic terms. A woman from Ohio, whose son did not return from Vietnam alive, felt that the memorial should portray "the courage, the bravery" of the soldiers and not "denigrate our men in black marble." Another grieving parent wanted a monument "symbolic of the courage and patriotism of the young men of the Vietnam experience." A man from Virginia queried, "Can't we find a patriot to design this memorial?"⁶

Most citizens who protested wrote directly to President Ronald Reagan and asked him to assist them in obtaining a more explicitly patriotic design. One retired Air Force officer argued that the memorial must be one that can be "looked up to, not fallen into." Another

man asked Reagan if he would like to be remembered by a "black hole in the ground." John Gustafson of Elgin, Illinois, compared the proposal to past monuments: "I suggest that a memorial be built that is similar to the Iwo Jima memorial in Washington, D.C., that shows the true heroism that American G.I.'s displayed in Vietnam. There were many examples of heroism in Vietnam and any of these would be a fine tribute to all Vietnam veterans."⁷

Several people went so far as to submit drawings of their own for the memorial. Regis Brawdy, a disabled veteran who argued that a "hole in the ground" did not conform to his idea of being honored, submitted a sketch of a large "V" for victory rising into the sky with an American flag in the middle of the structure. Brawdy proposed that the names of living vets be placed on one side of the monument and the names of the dead be inscribed on the reverse side. An Army officer, G. S. Robinson, thought the black granite proposal was not "inspirational like the Washington Monument" and suggested a white marble column carved in the form of a bamboo stalk that was entangled in a strand of barbed wire. The stalk stood for Southeast Asia, and the wire represented tyranny. In this rendition both the stalk and the wire were broken to symbolize the American effort to break the Communist stronghold on the Vietnamese people.⁸

A compromise eventually worked out between conflicting sides was announced by Scruggs and Warner in 1982. The original design with names of the dead would stand. Added to the site, however, would be an American flag, a "heroic statue" of three soldiers from the Vietnamese conflict, and the inscription "God Bless America" on the monument itself. The powerful and dominant interests of patriots and nationalists could not let a text composed only by and about ordinary people and ordinary emotions stand alone. The profane was clearly a threat to the sacred. Scruggs incorrectly argued that the original design represented neither victory nor defeat but simply the acknowledgment of those who served. He was more insightful when he commented that aesthetically the design did not need the additional statue of the "heroic soldiers" but "politically it does."⁹

Thousands of Vietnam veterans converged on Washington during the week of November 7, 1982, for the monument dedication ceremonies. This commemorative occasion would witness the expression of the same conflicting set of interests, however, that had marked the discussion over the promotion and design of the monument itself. Patriotic language and symbols punctuated the entire affair, but most people—veterans, relatives, and friends—came to voice their personal sentiments: grief for fallen comrades, a desire to recognize the ordinary soldiers, and sorrow over the loss of loved ones. Expressions

of national greatness, unity, and loyalty to the nation were not only infrequent but often contradicted.

Personal feeling and private agendas were powerfully articulated. The parents of Robert Rosar who was killed in the Mekong Delta in 1968 came from Colorado to honor the memory of their son. Wilma Rosar explained: "It [the monument] means so much to us. It's a very deep thing, our loss, it was absolutely devastating." Rosar's father said the memorial provided a sense of honor concerning Bob's death that he had never felt before.¹⁰

Other veterans came to the commemoration for personal reasons. Jack Ferrier came from Hartford, Connecticut, "to find peace with myself and spend some time with my memories." He explained that he lost many friends in a military offensive in 1969. Jim Everett of Orlando, Florida, came to the commemoration out of a sense of frustration, "Nobody understands me," he told a reporter for the *Washington Post*, "not unless they've been through it." Everett said that the main reason he came was that he had lost contact with every friend he made in Vietnam. David Gray drove with three veteran friends from Indianapolis to Washington because he felt a tribute to the soldiers who fought in Vietnam was long overdue. "And all these guys who were wounded in Vietnam got no recognition," he asserted. "We couldn't separate the politics of the war from the veterans themselves."¹¹

A massive parade of veterans that preceded the monument dedication on November 13 was disorderly when compared to the normal civil and military parades that marked American commemorative activity. Respect for authority, order, and unity were less in evidence as men and women marched in and out of uniform, brought along pets, and carried either small American flags or placards that criticized political decisions from the past: "We Killed, We Bled, We Died for Worse than Nothing"; "No More Wars. No More Lies." This presentation of views in opposition to the ideology of national unity and reconciliation and national power was another indication that the public discussion over the memory of this war involved significant contention and debate. The parade's theme, "Marching Along Together Again," actually expressed sentiments of loyalty to a community or brotherhood of soldiers rather than loyalty to a nation of patriotic citizens.¹²

From the moment the monument was dedicated, expressions of personal pain, grief, and loss were manifested. People who visited the wall touched the names of loved ones and wept openly. As evening fell some veterans kept a vigil and handed out flashlights so people could find the names for which they were searching. One night,

shortly after the dedication, the parents of one fallen soldier apparently left an old pair of cowboy boots at the base of the black granite monolith. Shortly after that, Eleanor Wimbish of Maryland left the first of more than twenty letters she would write to her dead son. She said that she wanted to bring something personal to the wall. By 1985 the National Park Service began to collect the thousands of personal mementos that were being left behind. These small remembrances said little of national greatness but much of what dominated individual memories. They included yellowed pictures of teenage soldiers, plastic roses, childhood teddy bears, baseball caps, worn Army dogtags, diaries, postcards written from war zones, and love letters. A park service technician who helped catalog the items left behind told a reporter that the mementos left him "a little misty." He claimed that these objects were "not like history" but had an "immediacy" about them.¹³ What he might have added was that they were not really like the history that was usually commemorated in public.

This effort to restate the human pain and sorrow of war rather than the valor and glory of warriors and nations, moreover, originated in the experience of war itself. The monument to the veterans was not only a simple memory invention of survivors moved by feelings they had after the war but represented a continuance of a conflict that had originated in Vietnam. That dispute was rooted in the contradictory perceptions of ordinary soldiers and powerful political structures such as the nation-state. The former felt mostly pain and frustration while government or official statements about the war talked of military progress, often expressed in terms of "body counts," and the need for international security against Communist expansion.

Soldiers did not always experience the conflict as the government described it. In an incisive examination of many of the literary accounts of the war, Christie Norton Bradley has demonstrated how much of that literature was produced by writers who were actually in Vietnam and who felt a sense of duty not to the nation but to the individuals they knew who fought and died. They were intent on providing not histories of the war but accounts of how the war felt and was perceived by those who were there. The most powerful of these writers shared the sense of the soldiers that official reports of the war—by the government and news-gathering agencies—failed to accurately relate what it meant to be there. To the extent that survivors restated the war experience in ways that did not directly serve the interests of the nation-state, they were not simply feeling guilt for having survived but were sustaining an oppositional attitude that had been created by the warriors themselves.¹⁴ Scruggs, wounded in action as a "grunt," reflected much of this war experience and this an-

tagonistic attitude toward those in authority. Not surprisingly, key critics of the original design such as Webb and Carhart were graduates of service academies where they had been fully exposed to the ideologies of national service and glory.

Despite concessions to the demands of patriots and nationalists, the Vietnam memorial clearly represented the triumph of one set of interests over another. It could be viewed by people as an embodiment of the ideals of patriotism and nationalism and as an expression of comradeship with and sorrow for the dead. But unmistakably the latter theme predominated over the former, a point which troubled opponents of the original design.

Part One

MEMORY IN THE PRESENT AND THE PAST

Collective memory . . . is a current of continuous thought whose continuity is not at all artificial, for it retains from the past only what still lives or is capable of living in the consciousness of groups keeping the memory alive.

—*Maurice Halbwachs*

Fairy tales are told for entertainment. You've got to distinguish between the myths that have to do with the serious matter of living life in terms of the order of society and of nature and stories with some of those motifs that are told for entertainment.

—*Joseph Campbell*

It will be seen that the control of the past depends above all on the training of memory.

—*George Orwell*

Nationalism usually conquers in the name of a putative folk culture.

—*Ernest Gellner*

The Memory Debate: An Introduction

THE STORY of the Vietnam Veterans Memorial underscores a very fundamental point. The shaping of a past worthy of public commemoration in the present is contested and involves a struggle for supremacy between advocates of various political ideas and sentiments. It is the creation of public memory in commemorative activities celebrating America's past and the dramatic exchange of interests that are involved in such exercises that constitute the focus of this book.

The debate over the Vietnam memorial involved two main sides. The dominant interest expressed in the memorial originated in the consciousness of ordinary people most directly involved in the war: veterans who fought there and people who cared about them. In the context of American society they represented a vernacular culture which formulated specialized concerns during the war, such as their critique of official interpretations of the conflict, and after the war, such as their reverence for the dead. They manifested these concerns in the memorial itself. Standing opposed to their concerns and ultimately accommodating them were the defenders of the nation-state. The structure of national power was safeguarded by national political leaders who saw in the monument a device that would foster national unity and patriotism and many veterans and other citizens who celebrated the ideal of patriotic duty. These guardians of the nation were representatives of an overarching or official culture which resisted cultural expressions that minimized the degree to which service in Vietnam may have been valorous.

Public memory emerges from the intersection of official and vernacular cultural expressions. The former originates in the concerns of cultural leaders or authorities at all levels of society. Whether in positions of prominence in small towns, ethnic communities, or in educational, government, or military bureaucracies, these leaders share a common interest in social unity, the continuity of existing institutions, and loyalty to the status quo. They attempt to advance these concerns by promoting interpretations of past and present reality that reduce the power of competing interests that threaten the attainment of their goals. Official culture relies on "dogmatic formalism" and the restate-

ment of reality in ideal rather than complex or ambiguous terms. It presents the past on an abstract basis of timelessness and sacredness. Thus, officials and their followers preferred to commemorate the Vietnam War in the ideal language of patriotism rather than the real language of grief and sorrow. Normally official culture promotes a nationalistic, patriotic culture of the whole that mediates an assortment of vernacular interests. But seldom does it seek mediation at the expense of ascendancy.¹

Vernacular culture, on the other hand, represents an array of specialized interests that are grounded in parts of the whole. They are diverse and changing and can be reformulated from time to time by the creation of new social units such as soldiers and their friends who share an experience in war or immigrants who settle a particular place. They can even clash with one another. Defenders of such cultures are numerous and intent on protecting values and restating views of reality derived from firsthand experience in small-scale communities rather than the "imagined" communities of a large nation. Both cultures are championed by leaders and gain adherents from throughout the population, and individuals themselves can support aspects of both cultures at once. But normally vernacular expressions convey what social reality feels like rather than what it should be like. Its very existence threatens the sacred and timeless nature of official expressions.

Public memory is produced from a political discussion that involves not so much specific economic or moral problems but rather fundamental issues about the entire existence of a society: its organization, structure of power, and the very meaning of its past and present. This is not simple class or status politics, although those concerns are involved in the discussion, but it is an argument about the interpretation of reality; this is an aspect of the politics of culture. It is rooted not simply in a time dimension between the past and the present but is ultimately grounded in the inherent contradictions of a social system: local and national structures, ethnic and national cultures, men and women, young and old, professionals and clients, workers and managers, political leaders and followers, soldiers and commanders. Its function is to mediate the competing restatements of reality these antinomies express. Because it takes the form of an ideological system with special language, beliefs, symbols, and stories, people can use it as a cognitive device to mediate competing interpretations and privilege some explanations over others. Thus, the symbolic language of patriotism is central to public memory in the United States because it has the capacity to mediate both vernacular loyalties to local

and familiar places and official loyalties to national and imagined structures.²

Public memory is a body of beliefs and ideas about the past that help a public or society understand both its past, present, and by implication, its future. It is fashioned ideally in a public sphere in which various parts of the social structure exchange views. The major focus of this communicative and cognitive process is not the past, however, but serious matters in the present such as the nature of power and the question of loyalty to both official and vernacular cultures. Public memory speaks primarily about the structure of power in society because that power is always in question in a world of polarities and contradictions and because cultural understanding is always grounded in the material structure of society itself. Memory adds perspective and authenticity to the views articulated in this exchange; defenders of official and vernacular interests are selectively retrieved from the past to perform similar functions in the present.

Adherents to official and vernacular interests demonstrate conflicting obsessions. Cultural leaders orchestrate commemorative events to calm anxiety about change or political events, eliminate citizen indifference toward official concerns, promote exemplary patterns of citizen behavior, and stress citizen duties over rights. They feel the need to do this because of the existence of social contradictions, alternative views, and indifference that perpetuate fears of societal dissolution and unregulated political behavior.

Ordinary people, on the other hand, react to the actions of leaders in a variety of ways. At times they accept official interpretations of reality. Sometimes this can be seen when an individual declares that a son died in defense of his country or an immigrant ancestor emigrated to build a new nation. Individuals also express alternative renditions of reality when they feel a war death was needless or an immigrant ancestor moved simply to support his family. Frequently people put official agendas to unintended uses as they almost always do when they use public ritual time for recreational purposes or patriotic symbols to demand political rights.³

Most cultural leaders in the United States come from a broad group of middle-class professionals—government officials, editors, lawyers, clerics, teachers, military officers, and small businessmen. They are "self-conscious purveyors" of loyalty to larger political structures and existing institutions. Their careers and social positions usually depend upon the survival of the very institutions that are celebrated in commemorative activities. The boundaries of the leadership group are permeable, however, and can be crossed by rich and very influential

individuals. Seldom are they crossed by factory workers, homemakers, millhands, farmers, and others whose work and social position allow them little time and access to the organizations that shape most public commemorative events.⁴

The term "ordinary people" best describes the rest of society that participates in public commemoration and protects vernacular interests. They are a diverse lot, are not synonymous with the working class, and invariably include individuals from all social stations. They are more likely to honor pioneer ancestors rather than founding fathers and favor comrades over patriots as some did regarding the Vietnam memorial. They acknowledge the ideal of loyalty in commemorative events and agree to defend the symbol of the nation but often use commemoration to redefine that symbol or ignore it for the sake of leisure or economic ends. There is certainly patriotism in much of what they honor, but they do not hesitate to privilege the personal or vernacular dimension of patriotism over the public one. They are less interested than cultural leaders in exerting influence or control over others, and are preoccupied, instead, with defending the interests and rights of their respective social segments.

Because numerous interests clash in commemorative events they are inevitably multivocal. They contain powerful symbolic expressions—metaphors, signs, and rituals—that give meaning to competing interpretations of past and present reality. In modern America no cultural expression contains the multivocal quality of public commemorations better than the idea of the nation-state and the language of patriotism. On a cultural level it serves as a symbol that "coerces" the discordant interests of diverse social groups and unites them into a "unitary conceptual framework" which connects the ideal with the real. Officials use it as a powerful metaphor that stimulates ideals of social unity and civic loyalty. And its very real structure of local, regional, and national government constantly seeks loyalty and respect. But the component parts of the nation-state—its families, classes, ethnic groups, and regions—also attract loyalty and devotion. Citizens view the larger entity of the nation through the lens of smaller units and places that they know firsthand. And they frequently see the nation as a defender of their rights rather than simply a source of obligation.⁵ The symbols of the nation-state and the patriot do what all symbols do: they mediate both official and vernacular interests. By themselves they do not privilege one interest over another. That task is performed admirably by men and women living in space and time.

Public commemorations usually celebrate official concerns more than vernacular ones. This does not mean that cultural differences are removed from the discussion over memory. Most citizens can honor

the basic political structure of the nation, for instance, and still vigorously disagree with cultural leaders about what the nation stands for and what type of devotion it merits. They often express this disagreement not in violent terms but in more subtle expressions of indifference or inventive historical constructions of their own. For instance, the pioneer was a popular historical symbol in midwestern commemorations during the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. Its appeal to ordinary people resided in its vernacular meaning of sturdy ancestors who founded ethnic communities and families, preserved traditions in the face of social change, and overcame hardship. These defenders of vernacular culture were especially important to midwesterners who were anxious about the pace of economic centralization and the impact of urban and industrial growth upon their local places. Their commemorations of pioneers were so pervasive, in fact, that officials attempted to redefine these figures from the past as builders and defenders of a nation rather than of small communities or staunch supporters of local institutions.

Because the expression of patriotic and nationalistic texts, moreover, reflects both the interests of cultural leaders and ordinary people, it does not follow that an equitable compromise is reached. Negotiation and cultural mediation do not preclude domination and distortion. Usually it is the local and personal past that is incorporated into a nationalized public memory rather than the other way around. Local, regional, class, and ethnic interests are sustained in one form or another in the final product, but the dominant meaning is usually nationalistic. And this does not seem to be particularly wrong to most citizens. In fact, it appears to be "fundamentally true." As Maurice Godelier argues, it is when ideologies do not appear to the "exploited" as illusions or as instruments of their exploitation that they contribute effectively to persuading people to accept them. They can only do this if they incorporate—as the symbols of the pioneer and patriot do—meanings dear to a number of social groups that participate in the memory debate.⁶

One implication of the argument that the abundant patriotic messages of American public memory are rooted partially in the quest for power by leaders of various sorts is that patriotism is invented as a form of social control and that it does not naturally find resonance within the hearts and minds of ordinary people. Obviously this study cannot pretend to explore private hearts and minds. But it does present clues as to what the masses think and feel when they demonstrate loyalty to the nation-state. They certainly respond enthusiastically to patriotic messages and symbols with referential connections to their immediate environs and group. National commemorations

such as the 1976 bicentennial, for instance, celebrated both local, ethnic, and national history. But are they performing? Do they exhibit patriotic sentiments in the dramatic exchanges that take place in commemorative activities because they know that is what those in power want them to do? Or is the observation that American patriotism is "indigenous" and not fabricated as it is in Europe correct?⁷

This study of commemorative activity suggests several points on the matter. Leaders in the period under review here expended a very substantial effort to stimulate loyalty to large political structures. Ordinary people demonstrated a considerable interest of their own in expressing attachments to structures of a smaller scale such as local and cultural communities. Ordinary people also exhibited indifference to patriotic messages at times, especially when it came to paying for monuments, and a periodic determination to use commemorative time to pursue personal rather than civic interests.⁸

More suggestive is the widespread effort on the part of ordinary people to celebrate symbols such as pioneer ancestors or dead soldiers that were more important for autobiographical and local memory than for civic memory. In fact, because the vernacular dimension of memory would not go away it was susceptible to reformulation by officials. Constantly they honored pioneers for building a nation and fallen soldiers for defending it. But the patriotism they evoked on the part of ordinary people was not always grounded in official expressions but in the power of vernacular meanings officials tried to constrain.

Ordinary people do two things when they affirm loyalty to the nation. They do what leaders expect of them, but they also insist that much of what they value on a smaller and less political scale is important to them. The prominence of patriotism in American commemorative activities does not signify the complete triumph of the power of the nation-state. Patriotism itself embodies both official and vernacular interests, although most patriotic expressions tend to emphasize the dominance of the former over the latter.⁹

Indeed, a striking comparison could be made with French history. The pioneer symbol, regardless of the extent it served the interests of the nation, originated in the attempts of local communities and ethnic enclaves to mark their communal origins. In a similar fashion, Maurice Agulhon shows how the most powerful symbol of the French Republic by the late nineteenth century—a female figure named Marianne—originated in the vernacular culture of peasants in the south of France before it came to serve the official interests of national culture as well. The cognitive power of both Marianne and pioneers was certainly due in part to their ability to link the official and vernacular interests of political structures and ordinary people.¹⁰

It is not surprising to see several interests connected in the symbols that were most powerful, if we can accept the argument that the symbolic meaning of ideological systems emerges from a communicative process. Thus, both the pioneer and patriot symbols do what all symbols do: they restate social contradictions in a modified form. To the extent that public memory originates in discourse or the presentation of divergent viewpoints, it is not simply manipulated. Discourse can simultaneously be a servant of and a hedge against hegemonic interests. To put it another way, manipulation and invention do not go far enough in explaining how certain symbols assume dominance in public memory. In the United States, since the early nineteenth century, commemorative activity involved considerably more than manipulation of the past by officials. It involved the presentation of multiple texts or numerous kinds of symbolic communication.¹¹

Discourse or communication over the past, moreover, is not only vital but pervasive. Forums for discussion exist in the commemorative activity of ethnic communities, towns and cities, states and regions, and nations. Invariably the interests that are exchanged are numerous, and those most powerful in the social structure are influential in the discussion and the construction of memory. The fact that forums are numerous actually insures that a number of interests are articulated. The multiplicity of forums, however, does not prevent some interests from distorting the discussion to a considerable degree.

Regardless of the number of forums that exist or the complexity of communication over the past, the commemorative activities examined here—anniversaries, monument dedications, landmark designations, reunions, and centennials—almost always stress the desirability of maintaining the social order and existing institutions, the need to avoid disorder or dramatic changes, and the dominance of citizen duties over citizen rights. Accounts of fundamental change in the past such as the American Revolution, industrialization, migration, or war are usually reinterpreted in ways that soften the idea of transformation and promote stories of patriotism and national growth. Dramatic episodes of citizens asserting their rights, with the exception of the colonists of 1776, are almost never commemorated. The point is that although public memory is constructed from discourse the sources of cultural and political power are not simply diffuse. They are also unequal. Public memory came to be what it was in the United States because some interests exerted more power than others in the discussion and actually distorted public communication to an inordinate extent. Thus, distortion took place not through simple coercion but through a more subtle process of communication which Leslie Good suggests involves the "prevention" of certain statements being made

in public in a meaningful way. Heavy doses of patriotism frustrate the expression, for instance, of state obligation toward its citizens. The power of large political structures and what Stuart Hall calls "cultural leadership" coexists with and dominates the power of smaller structures—communities, regions, groups—in the process of constructing public memory.¹²

By the latter part of the twentieth century public memory remains a product of elite manipulation, symbolic interaction, and contested discourse. Leaders continue to use the past to foster patriotism and civic duty and ordinary people continue to accept, reformulate, and ignore such messages. Because many had been so accepting for a very long time, in fact, the original design for the Vietnam Veterans Memorial came as something of a shock to some and raised the possibility that vernacular interests might be more powerful in the future. The deep emotional response evoked by the monument also revealed the continued power of vernacular culture and the fact that it had been sustained in symbols of commemoration that appeared to be more hegemonic than they actually were. This tension between official and vernacular memory and how it was resolved in commemorative events forms the core of the analysis in the following chapters. It will be explored in the communal forums of ethnic communities and large cities, the regional forum of the Midwest, the national forums of the National Park Service, and historic anniversaries relevant to the history of the nation. The intent here is to peel back the mask of innocence that surrounds commemorative events and reveal the very vital issues they address.

CHAPTER TWO

Public Memory in Nineteenth-Century America: Background and Context

PUBLIC MEMORY in American commemorative activities was formed by the public presentation of multiple texts in both the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. To an extent the evolution of this cultural exchange conformed to the arguments of Jürgen Habermas. It became less combative over time as the power of the nation-state came to mediate vernacular interests and dominate public communications. At the same time the supremacy of state power by the twentieth century should not obscure the fact that at times this power served the interests of one political group more than another.

Essentially, the balance of political power in the United States—the context of public memory—was shifting and fragmented before World War I. The nation-state, a growing business class, regional and local interests, and the concerns of ordinary workers, immigrants, and farmers all asserted themselves vigorously. No interest dominated the entire nineteenth century, but the nation-state was very influential in the aftermath of the American Revolution until the 1820s. It regained political and cultural power for a time after the Civil War. Its power, in terms of asserting its dominance over various vernacular interests, was effectively rivaled, however, in two periods and, unlike in the following century, could not be effectively sustained. Beginning in the late 1820s a rise in regional and class divisions led to sharp exchanges in commemorative activities and to something of a decline in the singleminded focus on patriotism and national unity that had reached a peak in 1825. Similarly, by the 1870s the consolidation of interests behind the effort to save the union in the North and leave it in the South gave way to a blatant drive for power by a growing class of businessmen and entrepreneurs and the efforts of workers, farmers, and ordinary people to restrain and control that effort. In the end this contest would help bring back the political and cultural power of the nation-state itself.

PUBLIC MEMORY IN THE NEW NATION

Robert Wiebe has argued that nineteenth-century America was a society "without an institutional core." Clearly it had fundamental organizations in which all citizens participated—political parties, a court system, and schools. The cornerstone of the century's public philosophy, however, was unregulated competition, individual liberty, and local and regional autonomy. Political power was decentralized in local communities and regions and the influence of the nation-state was something to be feared and limited.¹

Despite the essential correctness of much of Wiebe's argument, his notion of a weak or underdeveloped nation-state must be modified. To the extent that public commemoration is a clue to the nature of political power itself, an argument can be made that the state, as a symbol and as a political structure, exerted considerable influence over politics and culture in the century. This influence was tenuous and often challenged by a variety of vernacular interests but was very real both because the nation-state was viewed as a resource for the attainment of leverage by various smaller interests from time to time and because it sometimes gathered a force and power of its own that could not be easily resisted.

In the first half-century of the new nation the major symbols of public memory in this country were associated with the American Revolution. That struggle not only represented the origins of the nation-state but produced a number of leaders, documents, and dates that served as important subjects for commemoration. Symbols had to serve needs in the material world, and no greater political need appeared to exist at the time than to ensure that the new nation survive. Consequently, symbols that generated loyalty and respect for the new structure of political power became widely honored including George Washington and, more slowly, the Declaration of Independence.²

The symbolic transfer of loyalty from the King of England to the new nation, something that began in ritual form before the Revolution, was solidified after 1776. In part this process was facilitated by the creation of a new "king" or symbol of central authority—George Washington. Scholars like Catherine Albanese have insightfully pointed out that these symbols of the Revolutionary era became less religious and more "humanocentric." She felt that "Jehovah" had stopped making history, and "the nation of patriots was obligingly making it for Him." Grounded in higher authority, the symbol of Washington and the new nation left little cultural space for competing

symbols such as Thomas Jefferson or loyalties on the part of citizens. Sociologist Barry Schwartz has reinforced the notion that Washington replaced George III as a symbol of leadership and civic authority partially because of the religious nature of American society at the time. He became a source of good in opposition to the malevolent English king. By 1781 Washington's birthday was celebrated with special dinners and "demonstrations of joy."³

Not all Revolutionary War symbols gained the relatively rapid approval that Washington did, although he was certainly not without detractors on the political level. The Declaration of Independence was not generally considered a sacred document at all before 1800. On Independence Day, which was commemorated immediately after 1776 to some extent, orators saw the day and the document as important reminders of the break with the mother country and not as a symbol of political rights such as "liberty." The document acquired its later meanings when it became embroiled in the political contests between the Republicans and the Federalists. Once Jefferson became leader of the Republicans, the party celebrated everything with which he was associated. This adoration not only concerned Federalists because they naturally wished to discredit a political opponent, but because they were troubled by the possible link between the Declaration, individual rights, and political rebellion that had been suggested in the French Revolution. Prior to 1817 it was not uncommon to find separate Republican and Federalist celebrations on the Fourth of July.⁴

In the 1820s the decline of Republican and Federalist factionalism and the rise of historical interest in the Revolutionary era led to a more cohesive view of the Declaration of Independence and the celebration on the Fourth. A certain amount of unity and reverence was achieved by a growing sentiment for aged soldiers and leaders who had participated in the actual Revolutionary conflict itself. The fact that both Jefferson and John Adams died on July 4th, 1826, as nearly every historian of the period has noted, lent an almost mythic quality to the date. The Jubilee of the Declaration of Independence became a "solemn moment," according to Merrill Peterson, that stimulated the growth of American self-consciousness and patriotism.⁵

The establishment of the Revolutionary era as a centerpiece for public memory in the early Republic and the movement to generate loyalty to the new nation was furthered by the triumphant return visit of the Marquis de Lafayette in 1824–1825. Touring towns throughout the United States, Lafayette's appearance evoked much discussion about the past and the present as well as genuine public affection for

the figures and events of the Revolution itself. Fred Somkin has demonstrated that Lafayette's pilgrimages to Revolutionary battlefields, his reunions with aged comrades, and the receptions arranged for him throughout the nation generated much public enthusiasm and interest. In New York City "overzealous patriots" actually attempted to unhitch horses that drew Lafayette's carriage and pull it themselves. Somkin was quick to point out, however, that Lafayette was not only a symbol of patriotism but a representation of political liberty for ordinary citizens as well, many of whom worshipped him for having left family and wealth in France to fight for liberty in America.⁶

The exaltation of the origins of the nation-state, however, did not come entirely from vague expressions of emotions but was also consciously expedited by the actions of cultural leaders. This was exactly the case when men of "social influence," part of the rising patriotic tide of the 1820s, formed an association in Charlestown, Massachusetts, to erect a memorial to the Revolutionary battle of Bunker Hill. These men were mostly from the class of entrepreneurs and professionals who were helping to make a new social order and appeared anxious to associate themselves with the heroic makers of the new nation. They planned to do this in ways similar to the rising commercial and professional classes of Albany, New York, that David Hackett found attempting to employ patriotism "to bolster entrepreneurial activity."⁷

The New England leaders argued that the new nation and its origins should be honored because it had provided the framework for the rapid increase in material progress. Public response to calls for contributions to the project were slowed, however, by a lack of interest—especially outside New England—and a lack of "progress" for working people in the Boston area. Although several years passed before sufficient resources were available, the groundbreaking ceremonies for the monument in 1825 turned out to be a major civic ceremony. Over two hundred veterans of the Revolutionary War and forty survivors of the battle of Bunker Hill marched in a long parade. "Glistening eyes" constituted the response of the marchers to the enthusiastic cheers of the grateful multitudes who lined the parade route and cheered," according to one account.⁸

The central event of the groundbreaking was an oration by Daniel Webster. His speech contained powerful exhortations for patriotic loyalty and further reinforced the attempt of a rising professional and merchant class to place their pursuit of material advancement and personal reward within the context of patriotic activity. Webster reasoned that his generation could win no laurels in a war for independ-

ence but could, in fact, accomplish other patriotic objectives. Specifically, they could preserve and defend what the Revolutionary generation had achieved. They could also improve upon the past by working toward material advancement. "Our proper business is improvement. . . . Let us develop the resources of our land, call forth its powers, build up its institutions," Webster exclaimed. Arguing that Americans were now much better fed and clothed and had more time for leisure activities since the Revolution, Webster insisted that the expansion of material progress must continue for "Our Country, Our Whole Country, and Nothing But Our Country."⁹

Seventeen years later in 1843, at the dedication of the monument, another elaborate celebration was held in Boston. President John Tyler and his cabinet attended and participated in a long parade that consisted of Revolutionary War veterans, military units, fraternal associations, and groups representing local educational institutions. The parade restated reality according to the desires of social and cultural leaders. It portrayed a highly ordered and unified society in which all citizens respected figures and institutions of authority. As Tyler, the veterans, and other prominent people moved along the line of march to the music of "The Union," men and women cheered and waved handkerchiefs in a symbolic display of patriotic and social unity. In this public ritual and space, all were expected to honor leaders of the present structure of power and believe that these officials were the heirs of the Revolution itself.¹⁰

A crowd reported to be about one hundred thousand people gathered near the recently completed monument to hear Webster again. Passages from his 1826 oration were said to have gained wide circulation and have become "household words throughout the nation." Webster again called for loyalty to the union. To him the monument stood for "patriotism and courage" and for "civil and religious liberty." But in his recounting of the past that led up to the Revolution and the monument to patriotism he reserved a special place for his favored middling classes. He claimed that among the colonists of English America liberty first manifested itself among the "middle, industrious, and already prosperous class," and the inhabitants of commercial and manufacturing cities. Webster compared American progress in commerce and liberty to the tyranny that he saw in South America at that time and declared, "Thank God, I, I also am an American." Several months later, in a speech before the New England Society of New York City, he again celebrated "eminent merchants" such as John Hancock and asserted that no class had shown "stronger and firmer devotion" to the preservation of the Union than the "great commercial masses of the country."¹¹

EXPANDING THE CONTENT OF PUBLIC MEMORY, 1830–1870

By the 1830s the exacerbation of class, ethnic, and regional tensions caused by economic growth and the rise of a strong Democratic party led to the expression of a greater variety of positions in public commemoration. Ironically, the war to save the union and consolidate national power further enhanced the multivocal quality of commemoration and stimulated the expression of even more interests that had been rather quiet earlier in the century. The effort at civic instruction and the promotion of loyalty to the new nation continued, of course, but it now had increased competition. More commemorative attention was given to local, state, and regional pasts, so much so that historian Wesley Frank Craven suggested that parochial attitudes made it difficult to muster sufficient public support for an appropriate celebration of the centennial of Washington's birth in 1832.¹² Virginia, in fact, expressed its state pride by resisting a plan to move Washington's body to the base of a monument that was being built for him in the nation's capital. Pride in local and state pasts were further honored by the formation of state historical societies in Connecticut in 1825 and in Indiana in 1830.¹³

Davy Crockett represented a new cultural symbol that now competed with Washington. As Daniel Boorstin noted, Crockett was vulgar and crude compared to the "dignity" and "sober judgement" of the first president. But Crockett also represented a definite break with the almost monolithic patriotic symbolism of the early nineteenth century. He stood for common people rather than leaders and for a frontier or regional rather than national community. Certainly the spread of the frontier contributed to the growth of the nation-state itself, and, thus, the Crockett symbol contained patriotic dimensions. But the vernacular rather than the official dimension was more powerful in this particular construction of patriotic symbolism than in earlier ones.¹⁴

As American society became increasingly stratified by class, ordinary people demonstrated greater independence in the use of their commemorative time. A good deal of evidence from the 1830s and 1840s suggests that Fourth of July celebrations were used by the working class to pursue leisure-time activities rather than express civic loyalty to the nation-state. In the mill village of Rockdale, Pennsylvania, in the 1830s, where "rowdy men and women" filled the roads, the Fourth consisted of "disorderly, political picnics." During the same period in Philadelphia such celebrations, according to Susan Davis, included disciplined marches and "fine rhetoric" about civic values by

voluntary militias and disorderly "tavern frolics" and informal excursions by members of the laboring classes. In Milwaukee native-born inhabitants spent the evening of the Fourth listening to serious orations about moral and civic values. German immigrants, on the other hand, gathered at local beer-gardens for fun and merrymaking.¹⁵

Ordinary Americans in this period not only exhibited some disinterest in patriotic rituals but also began increasingly to use the patriotic symbols and language of the Revolution for their own economic ends. Thus, some reformers and working-class organizations after 1830 began to celebrate the heroes of the Revolutionary era as defenders of individual rights rather than heroic builders of a nation. Instead of calling for deference to structures of national authority, they used patriotic language to support their claims for greater political power and social equality. Thus, it was the leaders of the early labor movement in New York and Philadelphia in the 1830s that revived the memory of Tom Paine and celebrated his notions of the right of workers to receive the full value of the products they produced and the need for all classes to share in the economic abundance of the nation. Opponents of labor claimed that such associations were disloyal because they were detrimental to the national interest. But some historians have insightfully revealed how groups of workers, especially craftsmen, marched through streets during this period proclaiming that the nation-state was not a symbol of patriotic duty but one of the rights of ordinary people to political equality with elites and economic justice. In many instances, as Sean Wilentz has noted, proud artisans and journeymen proclaimed that the continued survival of the Republic itself depended on the well-being of proud, independent producers such as themselves. In Cincinnati in the 1840s workers carried the American flag along with appeals for public support for their economic demands during Fourth of July parades.¹⁶

Although the Civil War stimulated considerable patriotic fervor in the North, it actually sustained rather than reversed the growth of a more contentious and complex public dialogue over memory. The war drew thousands of ordinary people into dramatic episodes of tragedy and sacrifice. In a sense it furthered the politicization of ordinary lives initiated by the intensification of class differences. It had reconstructed the experiences of individuals and families in a way that the normal passage of time usually did not and, consequently, created a tremendous imperative to understand the drastic changes that shook people's lives and express how that reality felt. More on how individuals came to terms with a recent past of war and dislocation in the South will be presented below. But the aftermath of the war created countless possibilities for commemoration that had not been so noticeable before.

People who experienced the war instituted a broad range of commemorative activities that viewed the wartime experience of ordinary people—the soldiers and those that grieved for them and supported them—in terms of a “cult of sacrifice.” But the metaphor of sacrifice was defined in two ways. It could relate to the grief and sorrow people felt over the loss of friends and ancestors. This was its vernacular meaning. It could also stand as an act of loyalty or a contribution to the salvation of the nation itself. The creation of the medal of honor program during the war allowed the government to play a more direct role in official commemoration and in the creation of heroes than had been the case prior to 1860 when heroic symbols emerged in less rationalized and, perhaps, democratic ways.

Commemoration immediately after the war was preoccupied with a vernacular interest: grieving for the dead. Memorial Day became a time not only when ordinary people expressed their personal feelings toward ordinary people from their past but, as Mary Ryan has demonstrated, when women assumed prominent roles in public commemoration. In the South, just after the war, memory was placed not so much in the service of cultural leaders or structures of government but directed toward the needs of people to come to terms with death, defeat, and devastation. Beautiful cemeteries, “cities of the dead,” were the monuments that people built. In Richmond Memorial Day became an occasion when normal activity ceased and thousands of citizens walked toward Hollywood Cemetery carrying floral arrangements. In time the officers of this memorial place raised funds to bring back over twenty-nine hundred Confederate dead from Gettysburg for burial.¹⁷

National monuments to obscure fallen soldiers were created in the decade of the 1890s when Congress established national battlefields at Chickamauga, Chattanooga, Antietam, Shiloh, Vicksburg, and Gettysburg. Railroad companies were able to exploit these battlefields to stimulate tourist traffic and veterans from the North and the South gathered at some of them to demonstrate national unity, but the underlying interest served by the original construction of these symbols was the need of ordinary people to express sorrow and honor for the dead.¹⁸

UNREGULATED MEMORY

Raw political and economic conflict dominated the final quarter of the nineteenth century. A growing business class in the North and the South sought to nationalize the economy and expand corporate power. Workers, farmers, immigrants, and other ordinary people

struggled to regulate that effort in ways that would temper the breath-taking pace of change and allow for their participation in the formation of public and economic policy. The resulting clash of interests produced not only class and political conflict but sharp cultural exchanges over the issue of public memory.

Cultural leaders, especially entrepreneurs, intellectuals, and professionals, in the North and the South intervened in the discussion over memory in ways that celebrated the role of elites who came before them and ideals such as material progress that they cherished. Prominent members of New York society organized a lavish celebration of the centennial of Washington's inaugural in 1889 partially because they saw the first president as a product of “colonial nobility” and a representation of how important all elites were to American society. During the celebration of the four-hundredth anniversary of the landing of Columbus in 1892, businessmen and civic leaders organized massive parades in Chicago and New York that reinforced notions of civic order with large contingents of military units and orderly citizens marching in the various fraternal and ethnic units. In a period of intense class conflict, it was Italian-American businessmen riding in carriages that led the Italian parade in Chicago and not lowly immigrant workers.¹⁹

The 1876 centennial exposition held in Philadelphia to commemorate the birth of the nation revealed just how influential business leaders in the late nineteenth century could be. The chief organizers of the event were mostly “self-made men” so dominant in the public and economic life of the late nineteenth century. General Joseph Hawley, a newspaper publisher and former congressman, was president of the centennial commission. John Walsh, a Philadelphia merchant, was head of the centennial's board of finance and, along with others, represented Philadelphia's very real interest in promoting itself as well as commemorating a national event. Other exposition planners included manufacturers, lawyers, and prominent officials. The majority of the financial support for the event came from the city of Philadelphia and private supporters; little was forthcoming from government on any level. The planners, moreover, were quite conscious of expositions that had been recently held in Vienna, Paris, and London, which received more public financing, and wanted above all else to impress citizens here and abroad with the nation's achievements in technology. Progress, a concern close to the heart of the rising industrial elite, was paramount here not patriotism, although no one for a moment proposed that patriotic rituals be forgotten.²⁰

Patriotic ritual and history were abundant at the centennial. At the opening ceremonies President Grant spoke and was escorted into the grounds by over four thousand military personnel. An orchestra

played "Hail Columbia" as the nation still did not have a national anthem. On July 4, 1876, patriotic oratory and a parade of Civil War veterans took place much as would be expected. And visitors viewed a nine-foot working model of George Washington rising from his tomb at regular intervals.

The central feature of the event, however, was not a historical or patriotic relic but a technological marvel. Machinery Hall was the exhibition's most spectacular attraction, and the Corliss Engine was the centerpiece of the hall that everyone came to see. Many considered the steam engine to be the "prime symbol of the centennial," the ultimate manifestation of American technological progress. The message for public memory here was that the past had been a prologue to the attainment of a sophisticated material civilization; working-class interpretations of a past supportive of equal rights were not to be heard at this event. It was American material progress, and inferentially, the group of industrial leaders supposedly responsible for it, that merited citizen loyalty and respect.²¹

In the four decades following the 1876 centennial celebration, American industrialists continued to organize giant expositions and fairs. In this period over one hundred million people attended events like the Chicago World's Fair (1893), the Pan American Exposition in Buffalo (1901), and the St. Louis World's Fair (1904). Created by leading merchants and entrepreneurs in their respective cities to promote local economies and celebrate technological progress, they were intended, in the words of Robert Rydell, to "organize the direction of society from a particular class perspective."²²

These exhibitions were more than commemorative activities but contained ample amounts of interpretations of the past. Native American life, for instance, was presented in exhibits of tepees, artifacts, and dances. The object, however, was not ultimately to study culture but to use Native Americans as a baseline for measuring the extent of material progress that a business class felt it had created. It was partially for this reason that the ethnological collecting of Native American artifacts became "frenzied" in the late nineteenth century. American and European museums bought and hoarded these objects in order to accentuate the material achievements of the present and offer an understanding of the "historical trajectory" in which they resided.²³

Visitors to the fairs received a version of the relationship between the past and the present that primarily served the interests of cultural leaders. The past was essentially a story of enterprising individuals improving upon what they found. Change was constant but desirable and purposeful. Most of what had come before, in other words, had

only one aim: to prepare the way for a technologically sophisticated society led by industrialists and entrepreneurs. In this late century triumph of a business class and a national economy, the symbols of progress, were treated in a manner that was not restrained by very much patriotic symbolism and rhetoric. In such an atmosphere memory became largely a servant of a particular social group.²⁴

Business and commercial interests were not only redesigning public memory in northern cities but in southern ones as well. In literature, schooling, and in public commemorative activities, Southerners began, by the 1880s, to devote an immense amount of attention to the formulation of a memory narrative called the "Lost Cause." In this public version of the Civil War southern soldiers had fought bravely but were simply outnumbered by the forces of the North. Southerners had a noble cause and had no reason to feel ashamed. Indeed, their leaders such as Robert E. Lee had preached sectional reconciliation after the war instead of continued resistance and, thus, could be counted as patriots to the nation-state.

This explanation of the past, which Gaines Foster has called a "public memory," served not only the psychological needs of defeated Southerners but especially the powerful interests of a rising class of southern industrialists who were anxious to resume activity with the North and who were assuming roles once played by the region's aristocracy. In their attempt to absolve the region of guilt and resume commerce with a growing national economy, they de-emphasized commemorative activities centered on grief and sorrow for the dead and defeat itself and fostered a memory designed to speed the process of reunification while preserving something of a sense of regional pride. Conveniently they were able to link, in the view of Morris Janowitz, loyalty to a region to loyalty to a nation and maintain a traditional respect for the military and for authority.²⁵

No southern military leader and authority figure achieved greater status in this construction of public memory than Robert E. Lee. By 1900 this former leader of the revolt against the nation-state was becoming a patriotic hero and, in some areas of the South, more popular than Washington. The image of Lee was promoted not only by southern business leaders but by educators, clergymen, and other professionals in the region who shared their desire to rehabilitate the image of the South in the nation. Lee's picture was placed in southern schools, statues were erected to him, and celebrations of his birthday in Richmond attracted crowds in excess of one hundred thousand people.²⁶

Ordinary people took part in many of the commemorative events orchestrated by business classes and cultural leaders during the era of

national economic expansion. Because they might have derived gratification and enjoyment from these activities and took solace in some of their interpretations of past and present reality, however, did not mean that they abandoned their continuing attempt to state commemorative interests which were more directly related to their political and personal needs. This was especially evident in the many activities of the Knights of Labor in the 1880s. Leon Fink, in his examination of the group, described how the Knights formulated a political ideology that selectively drew its tenets from the Republican ideals of the Revolutionary era. Specifically, they attacked the growing inequality in society by invoking the Revolutionary era's calls for equal rights for all citizens rather than a vision of a community pursuing progress under the leadership of a business class. Fink revealed that the Knights often organized the only Independence Day parade in a town as a means of promoting their political goals. He claimed that their celebrations of Independence Day and Memorial Day were so "conspicuously sentimental," that their leaders frequently felt compelled to defend the organization from "spread-eagleism" and "Yankee doodleism."²⁷

The longstanding tension between the classes over the proper celebration of the Fourth of July was resumed with vigor in the following century. Ordinary people frequently used the day to pursue leisure-time activities rather than to honor historical symbols; cultural leaders continued to exhibit a sense of uneasiness over the neglect of patriotic commemorative activities and the potential for disorder that appeared to them implicit in the behavior of ordinary people on such occasions. In Pittsburgh historian Frank Couvares explained how local fire companies, which were at the heart of strong, working-class neighborhoods, assumed the task of organizing Fourth of July celebrations in the 1870s and 1880s. In such activities patriotic speeches were brief and most attention was directed toward the enjoyment of events like balloon rides, chariot races, and parades which allowed various groups of tradesmen and craftsmen to display their products and skill. In Worcester, Massachusetts, during the same period, newspapers actually complained that the working class had "desecrated" Independence Day by chasing "lubricated pigs." Drinking was so widespread in the town that local papers claimed that the day was devoted only to "liquid patriotism." Residents of Worcester's middle-class neighborhoods were even victims of pranks and vandalism on the day. And French-Canadian residents actually displayed more interest in celebrating St. Jean Baptiste Day ten days prior to the Fourth of July.²⁸

The proliferation of ethnic and class antagonisms in the late nineteenth century in fact stimulated a broad effort on the part of many civic and cultural leaders, especially from the business and professional classes, to regulate public behavior during commemorative periods. In Pittsburgh public ceremonies and games were staged by community leaders to replace the events formerly run by fire companies and neighborhood associations. After 1900 a Safe and Sane Fourth of July movement attempted to regulate rowdy behavior and accidents by regulating the use of fireworks. In many locations social workers and educators organized festivals and pageants for immigrant groups to encourage them to demonstrate their loyalty on the Fourth rather than simply have a good time.²⁹

Ordinary people not only put commemorative time to "unintended uses," but articulated historical messages of their own. The most powerful historical symbol they expressed in the later century was that of the pioneer. As it was used and generally understood in commemorations and reunions, pioneers stood for ordinary people from the past who were praised not so much for founding a nation but for starting families and local communities. They were recognized for the role they had played in preserving traditional values, even if they had actually fostered change, instead of promoting a hasty rush toward material growth. Pioneers certainly could be patriots, but they were also strongly loyal to vernacular structures such as towns and ethnic communities. Above all, however, they were the antithesis of business leaders who were promoting rapid change and the centralization of economic and political life. Not surprisingly, the symbol was expressed most strongly where economic and professional elites had the least influence—in the small towns and ethnic settlements of the Midwest and in the Great Plains.

Pioneers competed effectively for symbolic space with patriotism and progress during the celebration of the nation's centennial anniversary in 1876. In Des Moines, Iowa, on July 4, 1876, Old Settler Associations held picnics and reunions of local residents, and German immigrants sponsored a centennial ball to honor ancestors. In a major parade and civic celebration, organized by local officials and businessmen, themes of patriotism and progress had to share the line of march with those of pioneer life. Moving under an arch that held six-foot portraits of Washington and Franklin, the parade contained floats and groups of marchers that represented sturdy pioneers building cabins and settling the virgin prairie, ethnic and fraternal societies, farmers carrying banners that proclaimed pride in Iowa agricultural progress including statistics on the number of bushels of corn produced, and

finally, representations of George Washington and his bodyguards dressed in "full Continental uniforms and mounted" passing in review. The national celebration of progress and patriotism could not be presented in a local ceremony in nearly as narrow a manner as it had been at the centennial exposition in Philadelphia.³⁰

Commemorations in some places excluded celebrations of patriotism and progress completely. In 1876 Congress passed a resolution asking citizens to compile brief histories of their particular localities for deposit with the Library of Congress. Contrasting one local record from rural Iowa with the celebrations in Des Moines and Philadelphia revealed slightly different views of a past worth commemorating. Instead of the attention devoted to technological progress and the effort to promote notions of advancement, the "Centennial Sketch History of Grant Township, Lyon County, Iowa" was much more concerned with recording the achievements of ordinary people and ancestors. The handwritten manuscript left behind at the Library of Congress listed the names of the first child born in the township in 1871, the first person to die, and the first couple to be married. An attachment to local place rather than a nation was evident in the account of the settlement of the first white colony. The report indicated that settlers first came from Wisconsin in 1871 to establish homes on the "beautiful prairies" and indicated that they had received reports in advance of the "wonderful beauty and fertility of the soil." The local history described in vivid detail how the settlers suffered during the first winter in Iowa. They were ill prepared for the cold and endured frostbite and food shortages. These pioneers were called "courageous" and praised for their cooperative spirit (rather than individual achievement) in helping each other through difficult circumstances. Pioneer women were especially lauded for overcoming adversity.³¹

Pioneer celebrations and special anniversaries held throughout the Midwest at the end of the nineteenth century invariably focused primary attention on the first generation of white settlers in a particular place. A pioneer picnic in Muskegon County, Michigan, in 1882, exhibited pioneer artifacts such as a knapsack and a mortar for cracking corn. At the "Great Pioneer Picnic of 1887," in the same county, over five thousand people attended, and a reporter was on hand to actually record the reminiscences of the early white settlers. The obligatory orator recalled that in his youth he used to read history and mythology and "did not know where history began and mythology ended." He declared now, however, that the reminiscences and gatherings at pioneer picnics would preserve "history, so far as possible." Similarly, at the centennial celebration at Gallipolis, Ohio, in 1890, local people celebrated pioneers by filling a "centennial relic room" with

items handed down in their families, from a grandfather's hammer to a shawl made by a citizen's mother seventy years ago and candlesticks brought by immigrant ancestors from Europe.³² On the twenty-fifth anniversary of the arrival of Dutch immigrants to Holland, Michigan, in 1872, a parade was held. Included in the line of march was a wagon carrying the thirteen "surviving pioneers" who had come to the "kolonie." In 1887 at Zeeland, Michigan, townsfolk erected a permanent memorial shaft in the center of the village carrying the names of the first pioneers "as well as the names of the first who died in the hard struggle against the primeval forest."³³

It was also during the late nineteenth century that Abraham Lincoln slowly emerged as a major historical symbol. Certainly Lincoln, as any symbol, served a number of interests at once. He could rival Washington in his patriotism and service to the nation and exceed him in his martyrdom. Blacks often honored Lincoln for his role in emancipation, but such a symbol could also suggest that black people needed to be deferential to whites. But in the late nineteenth century, the Lincoln symbol was also a pioneer symbol. He was an ordinary man from humble beginnings, unlike Washington, who retained some of his pioneer mannerisms and ways of thinking. It was, in fact, a book by Lincoln's law partner, William Herndon, published in 1889, that solidified Lincoln's image as a pioneer hero. Herndon, according to historian David Donald, attempted to deliberately distinguish Lincoln from his "eastern contemporaries" and actually interviewed pioneer settlers in Illinois and Indiana to acquire just enough facts to enhance his pioneer status.³⁴ It may very well have been the ability of the Lincoln symbol to mediate the interests of ordinary people in pioneers and the interests of cultural leaders in national loyalty that ultimately explained its wide appeal.

A POLITICAL CULTURE FOR THE NEXT CENTURY

The unrestrained drive of a business class for political and cultural power in the late nineteenth century and the powerful defense of local and vernacular interests it provoked actually created a willingness on the part of many social groups for some form of cooperation. A political vision emerged that emphasized the interest all social groups had in maintaining the viability of an evolving national economy and the need for a more powerful nation-state that could mediate and regulate both politics and culture. The move toward national integration was led primarily by leaders of growing corporations whose fate was in-

creasingly tied to the new national market. But they were not alone, as Martin Sklar has argued, and were joined by the burgeoning ranks of professionals who derived much prestige from their national ties to peers, reformers who sought to limit the excesses of class conflict and economic deprivation, and workers and farmers in numerous locales who saw the need to maintain some form of regulation over both the growing economy and corporate leaders. Inevitably the collective desire to influence a national economy led to a related need to enhance the power of the nation-state—an entity that many perceived to be an ally in their quest for moderating the unregulated change and competition of the late century.³⁵

The movement toward the centralization of political power led to the formulation by the early twentieth century of what Sklar calls “corporate liberalism,” a political vision that dominated American politics and public discourse through much of the twentieth century. At the foundation of this vision was the belief that a powerful nation-state could regulate economic life without destroying the essential power and privilege of large corporations and that a need existed for a pluralist political process that would allow the participation of a number of groups—laborers, farmers, professionals—in the fashioning of public policy. Although cooperation was emphasized more than competition, a pluralistic system did not foreclose the possibility that some interests would dominate others from time to time. By implication, consequently, the discourse over public memory in the twentieth century would be shaped to a greater extent than it had been in the century before by the administration of state power over pluralistic interests.³⁶

The reconstruction of the political system was accompanied by other forms of national consolidation. Voters were mobilized increasingly by centralized educational campaigns. Community-based political parades and rallies, the basis for the vast public support for political parties in the nineteenth century, declined in importance as locales were flooded with publications from distant offices. Intellectuals and other citizens in the North even transformed the meaning of American nationalism and patriotism after the Civil War by creating an “organic theory of nationalism.” As Merle Curti explained, this new definition celebrated the nation as the “highest form of human association” and discounted arguments that individuals and locales had any right to break their ties to it. Curti located the impulse for this cultural defense of national power in the search for social unity and cohesion that was exacerbated by the intensified class and ethnic struggles of the late century.³⁷

Few supporters of the new order of corporate liberalism and central power, however, could have foreseen the expansion of state power that took place during World War I. State control was extended into areas of economic planning, labor relations, and public opinion. Put simply, World War I enlarged the statist dimension of corporate liberalism at the expense of the pluralist dimension. Groups at odds with the nation-state’s war agenda—usually labor and ethnic leaders—were prevented from participating in public exchanges. The trend toward educational politics was accelerated by the launching of a systematic propaganda effort to defend the interests of the nation-state and the importance of unquestioned patriotism. Although the exercise of state power subsided considerably after 1920, its presence did not shrink in ways that it had in the century before.

Corporate liberalism survived the postwar period and business, labor, agriculture, and the state all worked to exert some regulation of the economy and public policy. But few would argue that the corporate body, or what Ellis Hawley has called the “associative state,” was composed of representatives with equal amounts of power or influence over state action. In the 1920s business interests stood above those of labor which had been weakened during the war. In the following decade the situation was reversed as New Deal policy simultaneously responded to the demands and needs of the working class and regulated those calls and the claims of other groups by further consolidating state power. These trends would be evident in the expressions of memory as well.³⁸

The culmination of a long historical process that consolidated the power of the nation-state and liberal corporatism came with the Cold War. The enforced consolidation and centralization of American life during World War II was maintained during years of Cold War tensions. Armed conflict was followed by ideological battles with the Soviet Union and national pride in the achievement of defeating Germany and Japan. Yet, the period after 1945 witnessed a greater degree of pluralist politics than the one after 1918. Extremism of any kind could not be tolerated if some degree of consensus and unity were to be achieved to resist the Soviet threat. Labor radicalism had already been tempered somewhat in the war itself, and McCarthyism would eventually be restrained. The 1950s and the early 1960s essentially witnessed a period of relative equilibrium among vernacular interests in the public sphere and an agreement that the nation-state must be defended and supported.³⁹

It was not until the later 1960s that the “decorum of the liberal consensus” was shattered.⁴⁰ The power and the policies of the nation-

state and the national economic system, the foundation of the consensus, were bitterly attacked by Vietnam War protestors, angry youth, alienated blacks, and women. Vernacular power for blacks, neighborhoods, and even whites was espoused. Public discourse was characterized more by discussion over citizen rights than citizen duties, something that had not taken place for a considerable amount of time. Reservations over a structure of power that had slowly drained strength from local communities, ethnic groups, and ordinary people were expressed in a determined fashion. Links between personal lives and the nation-state, solidified during the past five decades, appeared weakened.

In the nineteenth century the power of the nation-state as a cultural and political symbol was effectively challenged by vernacular interests. Its ability to dominate the discourse over the past was frequently in doubt, and vernacular interests clashed in very direct ways. Indeed, it was the unregulated nature of both political and cultural conflict between vernacular interests that helped explain the rising power of the nation-state in the twentieth century and its ability to dominate collective memory. The political structure that fostered a patriotic and nationalistic public memory in the first half of the twentieth century was the result not only of contemporary events but of debates and arguments that had come in the century before.